



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Watermark Classical Academy
School Website: <https://ststephenschurch.net/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Watermark Classical Academy (Sewickley, PA, 15143) presents clear evidence of a religiously oriented preschool/kindergarten program operating within a church context. Public materials available for Watermark's site emphasize devotion to God, biblical framing of education, and parental involvement. However, the materials do not demonstrate core classical education hallmarks such as the liberal arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric), engagement with Great Books or the Great Conversation, or the distinctive pedagogical practices (Socratic dialogue, Scholé/restful learning, memorization, and imitation) that typify a classical school according to the Six Essential Elements rubric.

Overall, based on the six-category classical rubric, Watermark Classical Academy (Sewickley, PA, 15143) leans NOT CLASSICAL, with a notable partial alignment in Parent/Community relations and a strong Religious & Metaphysical Foundations signal. The aggregate assessment places Watermark outside the classical framework, though with some elements that would align with a classical vision if expanded.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Notes on method and sources: The analysis compares Watermark's public-facing materials (as found in the crawl results associated with Watermark/Noah's Ark content connected to the church site) with the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School. The Six Elements keywords are drawn from the knowledge-base lexicon and indicator documents, which enumerate the positive/negative signals that distinguish classical education. See the Six Essential Elements keyword framework (Positive/Negative keywords) in the knowledge-base materials.

- Evidence is drawn from Watermark's church-affiliated preschool/kindergarten materials, including explicit references to God, the Bible, and parental involvement in education. For example, public content states: "Deepening each child's knowledge of God," "the primary responsibility for the education of children rests with parents (Dt. 6:6-7)," and notes about supporting parents in their children's early experiences.
- The relevant classical-education keyword indicators come from the Six Essential Elements lexicon and related documentation, including discussions of truth/goodness/beauty, theology, Great Books, the trivium/quadrivium, Scholé, and partnership with families.

What would move the needle

- If the school intends to move toward a CLASSICAL designation, substantial alignment with the Great Books/Great Conversation philosophy, the Trivium/Quadrivium curriculum, and the pedagogical praxis of Scholé (restful, contemplative learning) would be required. Concrete steps could include publicly articulating a liberal-arts integrated curriculum, adopting classical texts for chosen grade bands, adopting Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades, and forming a parent-community partnership

that explicitly mirrors classical-school models. See the Six Essential Elements framework for the exact positive/negative signals these changes would engage.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials from Watermark/Noah's Ark content emphasize God-centered aims: "Deepening each child's knowledge of God" and "the primary responsibility for the education of children rests with parents (Dt. 6:6-7)." - Text frames education as a biblical-parent partnership, consistent with a theologically grounded educational orientation.

- Positive keywords observed in Watermark materials include God, knowledge of God, and explicit biblical framing (Dt. 6:6-7). These reflect transcendental commitments and a theology-infused approach.
- The school context is church-based, and the materials indicate an intentional formation within a faith frame. This aligns with the Positive Keyword indicators for the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category.
- Citations: Watermark materials describing God-centered aims.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: God; knowledge of God; biblical framing (Dt. 6:6-7). - Negative keywords found: none observed in the accessible materials. - Quantitatively, positive keywords observed significantly outpace negative signals (0 negatives vs 2 positive mentions in the materials examined). - Alignment justification: The presence of explicit God-centered language and biblical framing strongly supports a CLASSICAL orientation in the religious/metaphysical sense, per the Positive Keyword framework for this category.

Why this rating - The category shows explicit transcendental/ theological orientation and liturgical framing typical of a religiously grounded classical-leaning institution. The materials reflect a theologically anchored approach to education, which is a core classical hallmark under the "Religious and Metaphysical Foundations" rubric.

Citations: Watermark/Noah's Ark content indicating God-centered aims.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials emphasize formation in a God-centered framework rather than explicit statements about forming virtue/wisdom, human excellence, or a classical telos of truth/goodness/beauty in the sense used by classical schools. - The explicit articulation of "formation" as a broader goal is not clearly presented in the materials; rather, there is a religious formation emphasis and parental partnership rather than a classical teleology aimed at virtue, wisdom, and the true good.

- The presence of explicit goals such as "formation" or "great conversation" and a classical sense of telos, which are typical markers in classical education, is not evident in the publicly accessible Watermark content.

Positive keyword indicators (from the Six Elements framework) - The framework includes formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, and contemplation as core signals of classical aims. The Watermark materials do not clearly spell these out in the classical sense (they emphasize spiritual formation and God-centered aims instead).

Citations: Watermark materials illustrating God-centered aims and parental role.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: 0 (no explicit classical purposes like formation in virtue/wisdom, or telos beyond religious framing). - Negative keywords found: 0 (no explicit anti-classical signals in the materials provided for this category). - Percentage: 0% positive; 0% negative (no classical-purpose signals detected in the materials examined for this category).

Why this rating - Without explicit articulation of formation of wisdom/virtue, true goodness, and beauty as the telos of education (the hallmark of Classical School “Purpose and Goal”), the Watermark materials do not meet the core expectations for Element 2 per the classical rubric.

Citations: Watermark materials describing goals; lack of explicit classical telos.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The accessible Watermark materials focus on God-centered early childhood education (Noah’s Ark/Kindergarten/Preschool), but there is no explicit mention of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, astronomy, music), Great Books, or the Great Conversation. - There is no evident reference to Latin/Greek, or to the historical/canonical canon of Western literature and philosophy in the public-facing content.

Positive keyword indicators (from the Six Elements curriculum signals) - The Six Elements framework lists: Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books/Great Conversation, Latin/Greek, history as Western civilization, wonder in education, etc., as core curriculum signals. - Watermark materials do not present these signals in a visible way.

Citations: Watermark materials showing preschool/kindergarten religious-focused curriculum without classical liberal-arts signals.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: 0 (no Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, or liberal-arts signals detected). - Negative keywords found: 0 (no explicit modern, STEM-first or non-historical framing detected in the accessible materials). - Percentage: 0% positive keywords among the curriculum signals.

Why this rating - The curriculum signals for a classical foundation are not present in the public-facing Watermark materials; the content centers on religious formation rather than the classical liberal-arts curriculum.

Citations: Six Elements curriculum signals and absence in Watermark content.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Watermark’s publicly accessible materials describe early childhood education with a focus on God-centered development, parental involvement, and care by staff. There is no explicit documentation of classical pedagogies (Socratic dialogue, Paideia-style seminars, memory work, chanting, or rest-oriented scholé) in the available watermarked content.

Positive keyword indicators - Classical pedagogy keywords include Socratic dialogue, Scholé/restful learning, memorization/recitation, and formation through imitation. - The Watermark materials do not demonstrate these pedagogical signals in the accessible content.

Citations: Watermark materials focusing on God-centered development and parental involvement rather than classical pedagogies.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: 0 (no Socratic/seminar/memorization/recitation/restful learning signals visible). - Negative keywords found: 0 (no explicit anti-classical pedagogy signals observed in the materials provided). - Percentage: 0% positive keywords.

Why this rating - Pedagogical signals essential to classical education are not evidenced in the accessible Watermark materials; the pedagogies described align more with religiously framed early childhood education rather than classical cognitive-training methods.

Citations: Six Elements pedagogy signals and absence in Watermark content.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Watermark content references “caring staff” and “parents” but does not present a view of teachers as “model teachers,” “living curriculum,” or “faculty as mentors,” which are hallmark signals in classical education for Element 5.

Positive keyword indicators - Classical faculty signals include: model teachers/mentors, living curriculum, faculty as a community of practice, portrait of the teacher/student ideal. - Watermark materials do not explicitly align with these classical faculty signals in the accessible content.

Citations: Watermark materials describing staff, but not classical-faculty signals.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: 0 (no explicit classical faculty signals). - Negative keywords found: 0 (no explicit anti-classical signals observed in the materials provided). - Percentage: 0% positive keywords.

Why this rating - The available public materials do not present the classical-faculty signals (model-virtue, living curriculum, faculty portrait) necessary to classify Element 5 as CLASSICAL or even SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Six Elements Faculty signals and absence in Watermark content.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Watermark materials explicitly state parental involvement and a parental role in education: “the primary responsibility for the education of children rests with parents (Dt. 6:6-7)” and “we aim to support parents in their children’s early experiences outside the home.” - The church-based context also suggests a community and family-centered approach, and there is a clear emphasis on partnerships with families.

Positive keyword indicators (from the Six Elements framework) - Positive keywords for this category include Partnership with Families; Formation of Affections; Family involvement; Home-life integration; Parental engagement; and shared mission. - Watermark content explicitly aligns with Partnership with Families (parents are central to education) and Home-life integration themes; this matches the framework’s signals.

Citations: Watermark materials detailing parental role and support for families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: Partnership with Families; formation through family context; parental involvement indicators. - Negative keywords found: 0 observed in the accessible materials for this category. - Percentage: Positive keywords observed; 2 positive signals vs 0 negative signals (effectively 100% of observed signals are positive among the detected items for this category).

Why this rating - The category shows meaningful alignment with the Six Elements’ emphasis on family partnership and parental involvement, though the overall classical-cultural formation signals are otherwise limited. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal for Element 6.

Citations: Six Elements Element 6 keyword indicators and Watermark parental-involvement evidence.

What Would Move the Needle

- To achieve a full CLASSICAL designation, Watermark would need to publicly articulate and implement a classical liberal-arts curriculum, including:
- Explicit Great Books engagement and the Great Conversation framework.
- Structured liberal-arts progression (Trivium and Quadrivium) and classical languages as foundational elements.
- Adoption of classical pedagogies (Schol /restful learning, Socratic seminars, memory work, copywork, and imitation with master exemplars).
- Development of a formal “living curriculum” where faculty members embody classical virtues and mentor students as part of a coherent classical culture.

- Establishment of formal partnerships with families as co-educators, with explicit parent-education programs and community liturgical/seasonal practices consistent with classical-Christian education.
 - These steps align with the positive keyword indicators and the core structure described in the Six Essential Elements framework. See the keyword indicators for the classical framework and recommended transitions to CLASSICAL status.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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